

MODULE 35 / 40

House Wren

Troglodytes aedon

QUICK STATS

Length	4.3 – 5.1 in (11 – 13 cm)
Wingspan	5.9 in (15 cm)
Weight	0.3 – 0.4 oz (10 – 12 g)
Lifespan	Up to 9 years (avg. 1–2 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The House Wren is one of the most energetic and vocally exuberant birds in North America — a tiny, plain brown bird that erupts into a cascading, bubbling song far too large for its small body. Weighing barely a third of an ounce, it is among the most widely distributed birds in the Western Hemisphere, breeding from Canada to the southern tip of South America. Its scientific name, *Troglodytes aedon*, means "cave-dweller singer" — a fitting description for a bird that nests in any available cavity and fills the surrounding area with exuberant song. It is a faithful and enthusiastic user of nest boxes, making it one of the easiest cavity-nesting birds to attract to a backyard.

HABITAT & RANGE

The House Wren breeds across virtually all of North America south of the boreal tree line, from British Columbia to the Maritime provinces and south through most of the United States. It winters along the Gulf Coast, in Florida, and through Mexico and Central America. It inhabits woodland edges, suburban gardens, orchards, farmyards, and any area with shrubby vegetation near open land. It is highly adaptable and readily nests in nest boxes, flower pots, old boots, and virtually any enclosed cavity near human habitation.

DIET & FEEDING

- Insects and insect larvae — the near-exclusive diet
- Spiders gleaned from bark, foliage, and wood piles
- Beetles, ants, earwigs, and grasshoppers
- Caterpillars and moth larvae from leaf surfaces
- Occasionally small snails and millipedes
- Does not visit seed feeders — mealworms rarely taken

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

Despite its small size, the House Wren is one of the most assertive and territorially aggressive birds at the nest box. Males arrive on the breeding grounds before females and immediately begin filling every available nest cavity with sticks — a behavior called "dummy nesting" that blocks competing species from using the cavities. They will pierce the eggs of other cavity-nesting birds — including bluebirds and Tree Swallows — in neighboring boxes. The male's song, delivered from an exposed perch near the nest box, is a rapid, bubbling cascade that serves as both a territorial proclamation and a courtship advertisement.

NESTING & BREEDING

The male fills a nest box with small sticks, then the female selects her preferred cavity and builds the actual nest cup of fine grasses, feathers, and hair atop the stick base. She lays 3–10 white eggs with reddish-brown speckles and incubates them alone for 13–15 days. Both parents feed the nestlings, which fledge at 15–17 days. Pairs typically raise 2 broods per season. House Wrens will use nest boxes with a 1.25-inch entrance hole, which excludes European Starlings.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The House Wren's song is a long, exuberant cascade of bubbling, liquid notes that descends and rises in rapid succession — one of the most complex and energetic songs produced by any bird of its size. Males sing persistently throughout the day from April through July. The call is a sharp, scolding "chatter" — a rapid, harsh rattle given aggressively near the nest. The contrast between the plain brown plumage and the spectacular vocal performance is one of the great surprises of backyard birding.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Stable
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The House Wren population is estimated at 160 million individuals across the Western Hemisphere and is broadly stable. In North America alone, around 9 million breed annually. It has benefited from the proliferation of nest boxes and the fragmentation of forest into the shrubby edges it prefers. Maintaining nest boxes and reducing pesticide use to preserve insect prey are the most effective ways to support this species.

FEEDER TIPS

- Put up a nest box with a 1.25-inch hole — wrens take them readily
- Place the box 4–6 feet high on a post or fence, near shrubby cover
- House Wrens do not visit seed feeders — focus on habitat, not food
- Keep multiple boxes spaced apart to reduce competition with bluebirds
- Clean out old nests between broods to reduce parasites and encourage re-nesting

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Back & wings	Warm brown with fine dark barring
Underparts	Pale buff-gray, washed brown on flanks
Tail	Short, often cocked upward — brown, barred
Eyebrow stripe	Faint pale supercilium
Throat & breast	Pale gray-white
Bill	Slender, slightly decurved, dark

COLOR ME!

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